

SACRED STONES

When it comes to temple architecture, India is an embarrassment of riches. And the sculptural plenitude of the Hoysala temples of Karnataka puts them towards the top of the pile. On the UNESCO tentative list since 2014, the 'Sacred Ensembles of the Hoysalas' finally made it to World Heritage Sites list this September. Dating from the 12th and 13th centuries, the three most representative examples of Hosyala temple architecture are part of the inscription. These are the Channakeshava Temple at Belur, the Hoysalesvara Temple in Halebidu and, pictured here, the Keshava Temple in Somanathapura. UNESCO has praised the shrines for their 'hyper-real sculptures and stone carvings that cover the entire architectural surface'.